home is where the heart is

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32291155.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra) (mentioned)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Roommates/Housemates, Inspired by Music, different social groups forced to mingle, they're idiots your honor, Fluff, Roommates, Enemies to Lovers, but the enemies stage doesn't last very long and is one-sided, catra used to be rich but then her family went broke, adora likes making fun of catra's height, and finds it adorable when she gets mad, but who doesn't, i hope u have ur dentist on speed dial bc this is DISGUSTINGLY sweet

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home is where the heart is

by chasinghours

Summary

> In which formerly rich Catra loses all of her money, sinks down the social class, moves into a shitty, run-down apartment with Adora Grayskull, and learns that home isn't always what she thought it was.
>
> (The only thing that could possibly make this worse is falling in love with her idiotic, annoying roommate, and yet, somewhere among all the chaos, that's exactly what Catra does.)

Notes

> i've had this idea in my head for months. i kinda wanted to write a full fledged fic for it, but knew i'd never accomplish it, so i just decided to go ahead and write a quick one shot for it when i saw the creative challenge on twitter. it's alternative title could have been former rich and now "poor"(but she' s really just being dramatic since she sunk down to middle class) catra pretends to hate adora for 4k words and then accepts she doesn't and then they eventually kith. it's literally just so self indulgent and fluffy and i'm not even sorry LMAO
>
> and for those of u waiting for an update on hijnks soulmate au do not worry i am almost done 😌
>
> fic title from home is where the heart is by elvis, hope u all enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

OT ONE.

Catra doesn't consider herself to be a dramatic person. She thinks that people who constantly resort to hyperboles and exaggerations to emphasize the importance of their words have very few words of importance to say at all. She thinks that people who constantly use the term *literally* in every other sentence can never hold a proper conversation and have nothing better to do except laze around in their *literally* miserable lives.

So when Catra steps into Adora Grayskull's apartment ~~-her~~ her dusty , dismal, lower middle-class apartment ~~-she~~ she feels that it should be fairly believable when she says that she is *literally* at the lowest point in her life.

(If you had asked Catra what she imagined her last year of college would look like, she wouldn't have said this. She would have *never* in her wildest dreams imagined *anything* like this.

Life is beautifully unpredictable like that, she can almost hear Scorpia saying in her naturally cheerful voice, and Catra would just roll her eyes and give a half-hearted *sure,* because Scorpia is her best friend and, to be quite frank, deserves the entire world.)

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BEFORE

It starts, as most things in her life do, with a complicated, depressing, messy beginning.

Catra is only two years old when Shadow Weaver (nicknamed that by her adoptive sister Lonnie) adopts her. She's four when Weaver somehow manages to acquire enough money to put them on the map;as in, the *millionaire* map. Despite the fact that she really wants to know, (especially when they move into a big house with so many rooms Catra can't even count the amount of them on both of her hands), Catra never asks where all of the money comes from.

Lonnie doesn't either.

She's eight when she realizes that something isn't quite right, not with the way that people dressed in all black and appearing in white vans show up to their house every few months, and not with the way Weaver won't ever tell her or Lonnie where she gets all the money from, just that they should be grateful.

She's thirteen when she realizes that she's *smart.* Like, *really* smart, and she uses it in ways such as excelling at the top of her class with little effort or manipulating people into getting what she wants.

She's seventeen when she gets accepted into Columbia University, and she's eighteen when Weaver makes sure to tell her that it's money that got her in, not herself, and that both her and Lonnie owe everything to her.

She's twenty-one when everything starts to come crashing down.

She's twenty-one when the dirty, drug dealing business Weaver is a part of is exposed, and she's twenty-one when she watches her adoptive mother –among others –go to prison.

She's twenty-one when suddenly the funds she's been dipping into to pay for her adorable, one bedroom apartment on the Upper East Side of Manhattan suddenly disappears. She can't live in this apartment anymore, *that's* for sure. She's going to have to get a job,

and the one thing that she thanks the universe for allowing to stay the same is that she'll be able to finish out her final year at Columbia because her tuition had already been prepaid back when she first got accepted.

Aside from that, Catra is, to put it simply, broke.

She's twenty-one when her world crumbles, tears itself apart, and pieces itself back together like a shaken puzzle.

She's twenty-two when she moves in with Adora Grayskull.

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OTHER.

"So," Adora finishes, waving her arms all over the place after she has just completed the tour of the apartment. "What do you think?"

To be honest, Catra thinks the tour wasn't even needed, because there's literally *no* way she could get confused in a place like this. It's similar to her old apartment in the sense that it's also a one bedroom, but that's a bit of a problem, considering there's meant to be two people living here.

It's not similar in the sense that it's in downtown Brooklyn, where she's pretty sure she'll get caught in the middle of a robbery and held at gunpoint just by going outside. It' s not similar in the sense that the bathroom is across the hall and is so small that you have to squeeze your legs closer to yourself if you're sitting on the toilet and the door needs to be opened or closed, not like the large en-suite she had

connected to her old bedroom. It's not similar in the sense that the tiny living room and the even tinier kitchen are connected, basically one room. It's not similar in the sense that it doesn't feel like home.

Well, actually, scratch that. Catra's old apartment didn't feel like home, and in retrospect, neither did the mansion she grew up in, either.

(She's not too sure she knows where home actually is.)

She also thinks that Adora is gorgeous. That's pretty obvious, but objectively speaking, she's—she's pretty. She's taller than Catra by a few inches, has fair skin and blonde hair that's pulled back into a neat ponytail, and blue-gray eyes that could tell tales of the sky and the clouds all the same.

Scorpia would like her, Catra thinks. She would like Adora and her puppy dog eyes and wide smile. They would definitely go to the gym together, if the clearly defined muscles in Adora's arms are anything to take into account.

It takes her a moment, but she realizes Adora's still waiting for an answer. Catra blinks, glances around at the apartment, and then sighs.

"I think that this place is a dump," Catra mutters underneath her breath, and Adora's smile slowly fades. "And I can't believe I have to move in here." *Two days after my birthday, too,* Catra thinks, but doesn't say. She thinks this might have been the worst birthday present ever.

Adora watches her with a look of confusion, and then she seems to remember something. "Oh, that's right. Perfuma said you were the daughter of"—she cuts herself off when Catra tightens the grip on her suitcase and clenches her jaw, already not liking where this conversation is going. Adora blinks, and then shakes her head. "Anyway, assuming you're coming from like, rich people's standards,

I can assure you this is standard for a poor college student living in the big city."

Poor college student. Catra shudders when she hears the words, because that's basically what she is now, right? She has a bit of funding because Lonnie had always suggested she put some aside, just in case. Now, Catra has made a point to at least somewhat thank her for making her do it, but even so, that funding won't be enough to keep her afloat even in this low level apartment for more than a few months or so. She's now a *poor college student,* and will quite actually have no money soon if she doesn't get a job.

If it weren't for Scorpia's connection to Adora, Catra's not sure where she would be right now. Lonnie is comfortably shacked up with Kyle and Rogelio ~~has~~ has been for a couple of years ~~and~~ and she seems to have a bit more money put aside. Entrapta is still rich and living on the other side of the country, doing *God* knows what in some sort of laboratory, getting paid hundreds by the hour. Scorpia's living with her girlfriend, Perfuma, and it's through her that they even found out about this deal in the first place.

("I know a person who's looking for a roommate," Perfuma had told both Catra and Scorpia the day Catra came to Scorpia's apartment in a panic, describing what had happened with Weaver and how she was nearly broke and had nowhere to go. Scorpia had told her she could always stay with them, but that would mean having to sleep on the couch, so it was the immediate *very last* option.

"Rent is cheap, too," Perfuma had added. "Our other friend moved out recently, so she's looking for someone to share the cost with pretty desperately. I can let her know you're interested," she finished, and Catra, having basically no other option, had agreed.)

"Wow," Catra eventually mutters underneath her breath, because she still can't believe this is happening. Adora is staring at her with an unreadable expression, so Catra keeps talking without any prompting. "We're going to have to set a system up to maintain

everything;namely , the fact that your entire fridge seems to just be made up of spinach, protein shakes, and water bottles."

"That' s because I"—

"And," Catra adds, cutting Adora off and watching as she blinks in surprise. "Columbia is nearly twenty minutes from here, which means I'm going to need the bathroom earlier than usual. We can set a schedule for that later."

Adora's looking at her like she doesn't know what to think. After a moment of silence, she shakes her head as if to clear her thoughts, and then smiles and holds her hand out to shake as if Catra looks like someone who's interested in shaking hands with her. "W ell then, Catra. Welcome to Brooklyn."

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Catra hates her.

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In the mornings —the early mornings, when Catra doesn't want to be up —Adora is considerate enough to get out of bed quietly, using the flashlight on her phone to navigate around the room and the small closet while she gets dressed. Sometimes she'll still wake Catra up because she's a light sleeper, but when her eyes flutter open and she finds Adora trying her best not to stumble over something in the dark, Catra just groans and rolls over to face the wall, ignoring Adora's quietly muttered *"sorry."*

It's kind of pointless for her to do so, especially when sometimes Catra will wake up *again* less than an hour later 1) to the sound of cluttering pots and pans from the kitchen as Adora probably attempts to cook despite the fact that Catra can cook better than her even having grown up with people to do it for her, or 2) to the sound of her obnoxious friend being loud outside of the room.

She's only been living here for less than a week, but Catra *hates* it, and one morning when she wakes up in the dark to the sound of Adora's tall friend —Bow, she thinks his name is —and rolls over to find that it's not even seven in the morning, Catra swears she's never hated anyone more.

(Well, except for Adora's *other* friend. She's small —even smaller than Catra is, and that's saying something —and she's the worst out of the three of them. Catra has only met her twice, but she thinks she might actually not be able to physically restrain herself if she comes in contact with her again.)

The sound of the blender comes on just as Catra is about to ignore them and attempt to go back to sleep, and well, who can really blame her if she growls in frustration, rips her blankets off of herself and practically storms out of the room?

"Hey!" she shouts, coming to a stop just at the end of the small hallway. Both Bow and Adora turn to face her, Bow pressing a button on the blender that makes it stop, and Catra realizes they're both dressed in workout gear. They're both kind of sweaty, too, which means they're probably already finished with whatever it is that they

were doing. The prospect of that is just *beyond* Catra, because it's not even seven in the morning yet, how fucking early do they get up to be done by seven?

"Sorry ," Bow smiles apologetically , and Catra narrows her eyes in his direction. "Did I wake you?"

"Are you actually serious?" Catra asks through gritted teeth. Adora and Bow share a glance, which only unnerves Catra because she doesn't understand what *that* means, but then Adora is speaking.

"W e'll keep it down," she tells Catra after turning to look back at her . Catra doesn't believe that in the slightest, and it must be obvious, because Adora holds out a pinky. "Promise."

Catra eyes the outstretched pinky for a moment, kind of hoping the disgust is apparent on her face, because if she didn't even want to shake her hand while she was clean, what makes her think Catra's going to do a stupid pinky promise with her while she's all gross and sweaty? It doesn't matter that she' s extremely attractive for no damn reason.

Without another word, she storms back into their tiny shared room and slams the door shut.

(It only gets worse from here.)

The fact that they don't run on the same sleep schedules is bad enough, but another thing they don't share is a liking for the same temperature.

While Catra is *normal,* Adora constantly wants the fan on when they sleep despite the fact that it's basically already sixty degrees in their apartment at all times. She sleeps with only a thin blanket, and even though it's getting chilly out, still wears jeans and t-shirts. It makes Catra want to strangle her, because while Adora's nice and cozy in the bed on the opposite side of the room from her, Catra is bundled up in her heavy blankets and shivering until she gets warm enough.

She hates wearing socks to bed because she doesn't really like anything to be constricting on her feet ~~-s~~he even hates wearing shoes ~~-b~~ut debates on putting them on one night when a cold front hits and it's so cold that Catra almost launches the fan out of the window when Adora turns it on.

One early night, during a particularly *cold* night, Adora opens the window itself (which is at the foot of *Catra's* bed, thank you very much). When Catra asks her what the hell she's doing, Adora answers by telling her she loves feeling the crisp, chilly air against her skin, and that it's too hot in the apartment anyway.

Catra locks her out of their room for nearly an hour.

(It just keeps getting worse.)

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Catra is a night owl. This much is obvious, what with the way she doesn't wake up unless prompted till ten at the earliest, usually closer to eleven.

She doesn't mind it. She doesn't mind the late nights when she crawls into bed long after Adora has gone to sleep and lies on her bed facing the ceiling, unable to quite manage to fall asleep herself. Brooklyn never seems to sleep either, always awake and bustling with life. Catra's been a city girl her whole life, so the noise doesn't bother her, and it comforts her on some nights and she uses it to lull herself to sleep.

But some nights, she can't sleep. Some nights, she hears the background noise of Brooklyn through their thin walls and even thinner window, and lets her mind wander.

She thinks about all that's happened in the past year, from her abusive and absent adoptive mother getting thrown in prison, to losing all of her money and being forced to completely change her life. She thinks about the fight that shattered her and Lonnie's relationship just a few of weeks ago, and thinks about how if maybe she wasn't so *Catra* then maybe so many things wouldn't be this bad in her life.

Sometimes, she doesn't know how she'll ever come back from this. Sometimes, when it's late and she knows Adora is asleep, she cries.

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Adora regularly infuriates her, and Catra is starting to think it's on purpose.

For example, often times, Adora leaves things on high shelves. This would be fine and all if Catra could actually *reach* that far up, but she can't. One morning, Catra can't reach the box of cereal Adora left on the highest shelf of the kitchen, and Adora watches her struggle for a solid minute before finally taking pity on her and grabbing it herself.

"I'm just glad I'm not five foot flat, too," she tells Catra after she snatches the box out of Adora's hands.

"I'm five-two," Catra bristles, and only gets more annoyed when Adora refuses to stop staring at her with an amused smile.

"You sure? You're like, really small."

Catra puts the box down on the counter and turns to completely face Adora, arms crossed in unamusement. "Are you done?"

Adora chuckles and nods, holding her hands up in surrender.

Sometimes, Catra will complain about something like the shower pressure being horrible, and then Adora will tell her something like the water pressure is actually quite normal and that she's probably just used to rich people's water pressure.

"Has anyone ever told you how annoying you are?" Catra growls in response as she tries to flip through Netflix to find something to watch. Adora leans against the wall leading to the hallway, clearly having made it her mission today to annoy her with the amount of rich people jokes she's managed to come up with in the span of an hour.

Adora shrugs and looks incredibly pleased with herself as if the jokes she keeps making aren't actually the stupidest, unfunniest jokes Catra has ever heard. "I've been told once or twice."

"Good," Catra mutters, "because it's true."

Despite not liking him in the beginning, Catra warms up to Bow a little bit. It's kind of impossible to hate him, and even Catra can admit that.

The sparkly one ~~-w~~who she finds out is named Glimmer ~~-is~~ the one who Catra can't *stand* in any way.

"That's not how you make Crepes, by the way," Glimmer tells her in a stuck up manner one morning mid-November while she waits on the bar stool for Adora to get dressed so they can go somewhere. Catra

knows Adora told her where, but she doesnt think she cared enough to pay attention.

Catra clenches her jaw, because she *knows* Glimmer is just saying stuff to get on her nerves. "I don't remember asking."

Glimmer's silent for a moment, and Catra knows she's rolling her eyes. "Well considering Adora can't cook, and it's quite obvious that *you* can't either"—

"Okay," Adora starts, announcing her presence in the room. Catra's glad, because she was about four seconds away from strangling Glimmer. "You ready to meet up with Bow?"

Glimmer nods, and for some reason, it's the words *meet up with Bow* that calm her down a bit. Based on the way they were acting, she had suspected Glimmer and Adora were going on a date or something. For some reason, the idea makes a sick feeling coil around Catra's windpipe, almost worse than the ketchup and cream cheese sandwich she had the misfortune of watching Adora eat the other day.

She doesn't know what it means, but she plans on handling it the same way she handles all of her other problems: ignoring it until it goes away.

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END.

One night, sometime in early December, the issue regarding the fact that they can't seem to agree on the correct temperature for their room reaches its peak.

Catra's shivering, but this time, it's so bad that she wakes up in the middle of the night because of it.

Usually, this doesn't happen. Usually, she shivers only right after getting into bed, until she eventually warms herself up by burying herself underneath a few blankets.

When she wakes up, despite the fact that she still has multiple blankets on her, she's *really* cold. Catra blinks the sleep from her eyes, notes that it's dark out, and reads the numbers *3:34 a.m.* on the alarm clock. When she squints, she realizes she can see Adora's silhouette at the foot of her bed, staring outside of the *open* window.

God, Catra thinks, because she really just moved in with the most inconsiderate person on the planet, huh?

"Adora," Catra hisses, leaning up a bit. Adora turns to face her with a look of surprise, probably having not expected to see Catra awake.

"Oh, um"—

"What the hell are you doing?" Catra snaps, trying her best not to let her shivering become apparent when she speaks. "It's—it's so fucking cold in here, and why the hell are you staring outside of a window in the middle of the night anyway"—

"I couldn't sleep," Adora quickly answers, standing up from the chair she pulled up to the window and shutting it. The distant noise of Brooklyn in the night fades, and Adora pulls off the thin jacket she had on. "Sorry, I just—I wasn't really thinking. It won't happen again." She makes her way to her own bed, and Catra rolls her eyes and settles back underneath the blankets, only to hear Adora pause in her steps. "Catra?"

Catra grits her teeth. "What?" she snaps, wanting nothing more than to just be warm and asleep and wanting the girl who took both of those beautiful things away from her to just shut up and leave her alone.

"Are you...shivering?" Adora asks, kind of dumbly.

"No shit, Sherlock. It's fucking cold in here and you *know* I hate the cold, and you still opened the window anyway"—

She cuts off when she feels the bed dip behind her, the mattress squeaking on it's hinges. Neither one of them says anything for a long moment, and Catra sort of flinches when she feels an arm curl around her, but doesn't try to move out from underneath it.

"Is this okay?" Adora asks, tentatively. Catra blinks, and then mutters a quiet *yeah,* only because she's so cold she's kind of desperate and Adora, for whatever reason, runs really hot and the warm arm curled around her is kind of comfortable. She doesn't try to get underneath the blankets, and Catra finds that she's kind of disappointed. "I'm sorry for making it so cold, if—if I would have realized, I wouldn't have."

"Is this your way of making up for it?" Catra questions.

"Yeah," Adora breathes, and when Catra shivers again it's because she can feel her warm breath against her neck. "I've been told I run hot, anyway."

Catra doesn't have anything to say to that. They lie there for a few moments, before eventually, Catra clears her throat and, still refusing to face Adora, mutters, "It would be more comfortable if you, um, got underneath the blankets."

As soon as she says it, she begins to wonder what must have possessed her to possibly say something as embarrassing as *that,* but after a few moments, Adora lifts each one of Catra's blankets and wiggles her way underneath. She wraps an arm around Catra

once she gets settled, gently pulling Catra's back against her front and whispering the word, "good" underneath her breath.

"Yeah," Catra responds. She means it.

When she wakes up again, it's to the feeling of Adora getting out of the bed. Catra blinks a couple of times, and then rolls over slightly so she can peer over her shoulder, not sure if her sleep induced brain is just making things up when she realizes it's six in the morning — the same time it usually is when Adora gets up — meaning she stayed with her for the rest of the night.

Adora seems to realize she's awake, so she turns back to face her and whispers, "sorry. I'll turn off the fan so it's not as cold here anymore."

Catra is really beginning to wonder if maybe she just passed out from the cold or something last night and then imagined all that followed, but after a quiet muttered "kay," she relaxes once more and falls back asleep.

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Living with Adora: it's not... it's not *that* bad.

One evening, Catra is waist deep in her midterm reviews, *really* starting to regret choosing to major in physics, when she's distracted

by a light tap on their bedroom door.

"Come in?" Catra asks, a little confused. As far as she knows, none Adora's friends are here. Whenever she hangs out with Scorpia, she goes to her and Perfuma's apartment, and she doesn't really see why Adora would be knocking on the door to her own room.

As it turns out, it is Adora who pushes the door open and steps through. "Hey , sorry to interrupt, but I know you've been in here all day studying, so I just wanted to know if you maybe wanted to go grab something to eat real quick?"

Catra frowns and glances back down at her papers. Midterms start in a couple of days, but she's almost done with her reviews. She could probably finish them later.

"Uh, sure," she answers, pushing herself of f of her bed. Adora gives her a thumbs up and is about to disappear once again, so Catra frowns. "Adora, wait."

Adora curiously pops her head back in and lifts a brow. Catra kind of takes a breath, and then asks, "why'd you ~~um~~ m, why'd you knock?"

Adora stares at her for a moment, as if she's confused, before she straightens up. "Because I know you've been studying for a bit, and I didn't want to just barge in," she answers sort of bashfully .

Catra stares at her for a few moments.

She's not sure why she's thinking about this now, but it's just ~~it'~~ s the smallest thing, but it's *nice*.

Adora Grayskull is kind and sweet and warm, and it's then that Catra decides that living here might not be such a bad thing.

A little while later, they make their way out of the apartment and to Adora's old car.

It's *really* cold out today, a light wave of snow falling from the sky. Catra's glad she grabbed the flannel that had been strung across the back of the chair and pulled it around herself, on top of her jacket and hoodie.

(She'd been pretty sure it belonged to Adora before she put it on, but they made a compromise after that especially cold night fiasco a few days prior. Because Adora is the one who likes to keep it far more cold than necessary in their apartment, and because her clothes are bigger, warmer, and far more comfortable on Catra than some of her old clothes, she's allowed to borrow them for the rest of the duration of winter.)

Adora immediately blasts the heater on high when they get inside; apparently this weather is enough to make her cold, too.

"Where to?" she eventually asks after a few minutes of silence between them, Catra watching the bustling life of downtown Brooklyn. It's snowing a bit more lightly now, and when Catra rolls down the window when they find themselves in a bit of stop-and-go traffic, she realizes that even Brooklyn manages to smell like firewood and pine during the first snowfall of the winter. The entire thing makes her feel a little relaxed.

"Anywhere," she answers honestly, lolling her head against the seat to look at Adora. Adora lifts both of her eyebrows as if she's surprised, and Catra blinks. "What?"

Adora shrugs, and turns her attention back to the road. "Oh. Um, nothing," she murmurs, but Catra can tell she's hiding something by the way she's trying to stop herself from smiling.

Catra playfully nudges Adora's shoulder. "No, tell me." When that doesn't work, she leans back against the seat and pouts. "Please?"

Adora flashes a few more looks at her, and then sighs. "I'm just—I'm surprised. Ever since you moved in, I haven't really seen you that happy, and—I—*know* that you went through a lot in a short span of time, Perfuma gave me the bare talk about it, but it's kind of sad to watch, I guess? But right now, you just...you looked content, and I..." she trails off, and this time, Catra knows she's blushing. "I like that."

"Oh," Catra mutters. There's a moment of awkward silence between them because Catra isn't quite sure how to reply, and then Adora clears her throat and frowns.

"I'm sorry if I made you uncomfortable"—

"No," Catra cuts her off, and then turns her head to face her. Adora's driving on a bit of a busier street, so she can only flash Catra a quick glance, but it's full of concern. Catra takes a shaky breath, and thinks about what Perfuma told her a couple of weeks ago when she admitted to feeling like the cause of a lot of her own misery. Apparently, a step in overcoming that is allowing herself to be vulnerable in front of people, and well, Catra decides to take some of Scorpia's advice too when she says *there's no better time than the present!* "You didn't, so you don't need to apologize. If anything, I'm sorry for how I've been acting this past month and a half. I know I'm not exactly the nicest person, but I've—I've been bitchier than usual, and you're just so sweet and kind despite it, and I just...I'm sorry."

They come to a stoplight. Adora turns to look at her, eyes still a bit wide, but after seemingly searching Catra's own eyes for a few moments, her lips begin to curve into a smile.

"It's okay," she tells Catra. "I—um, don't make fun of me, but I've kind of found it all a little endearing. It's...it's cute, in a way, how mad you get over the simplest things." Catra lifts a brow in a teasing manner, and Adora seems to realize what she's just said. "Not that it's funny that you're mad, that's not what I mean, I just think it's funny when you get worked up over little things? Or, not really funny, but it's cute, and—wait, I think I already said that"—

A car honks behind them, startling both of them out of their stupor. Adora takes a gasping breath, and Catra isn't sure what causes it, but she seems to gain a bit of confidence and rests a hand over Adora's where it sits on the clutch.

You think I'm cute? a part of her wants to say. The other part of her wants to chastise Adora because Catra is *not* cute, and she doesn't care what anyone thinks.

What she says is: "Breathe, okay?" and after Adora nods and doesn't seem like she's going to have any more meltdowns, Catra leans back against the glass window and watches the buildings that continue to pass. "So, where are we going?"

Adora takes a deep breath, seemingly grateful for the subject change. "Well, I don't know about you, but I don't exactly have very much money, so," she suddenly pulls into the drive-thru of a McDonald's, and then looks at Catra with a grin. "I know it's not the healthiest thing, but I haven't had something from here in years and it tastes good, so I figured it would suffice."

Catra stares out the window as pedestrians cross the street and enter the building. "I wouldn't know. I haven't ever eaten from here before."

Adora whirls around in her seat, and Catra's glad the car is in park right now as they wait in line. *"What?"*

"Yeah," Catra shrugs. "I mean, most of my food was home cooked because my—Weaver wouldn't allow anything with a packaged cheap label underneath our roof, and when I moved out and started living by myself, I would usually just make myself something quick or order from fancy restaurants down the street, I guess. So like—like pizza, or hotdogs...things like that, I haven't really had."

Adora doesn't seem to have anything to say to that. Instead, she simply continues to stare at her with wide eyes, and Catra eventually

rolls her own eyes and crosses her arms. "Okay , you can stop staring now, weirdo. It's not that big of a deal."

Eventually, Adora blinks and shakes her head. She pulls up further in the line, and then looks back at Catra. "Sorry , I just—I'm going to make sure you try *everything,* Catra. Everything you've missed out on."She says it with such determination that it makes Catra giggle —actually *giggle,* and wow, she must actually be losing her mind — and Adora gives a breathy little laugh as well. "Sorry , I mean, only if you want."

Catra sighs, feeling lighter than she has in years. "Yeah. That—that sounds good, Adora."

Fifteen minutes later, after they've acquired their food and Adora has parked them across the street, Catra reaches into the brown bag to pull out the greasy paper. Adora groans from somewhere beside her, and Catra turns to see her already eating, looking totally blissed out. Catra rolls her eyes at Adora's dramatics and unravels her own burger, and just as she lifts it to her mouth Adora cries, *"wait!"*

"What?"Catra questions, watching as Adora grabs her phone from the cup-holder and unplugs it from the charger.

"This is a momentous occasion. Like, groundbreaking, unmatched, never done before. We need to make sure to document this, keep it for the record books. Woman, aged twenty-two, trying McDonald's for the first time."

Adora poses next to Catra, wrapping an arm around her shoulders and leaning her head in Catra's direction as she pulls the camera up to capture both them and the burgers. Catra simply lifts her eyebrows, unimpressed and a little amused by Adora's dramaticism.

"I'm about to consume something that will give my body severe stomach pains and heartburn, and you want to document it?"

Adora chuckles, and then snaps the picture when Catra gives a reluctant thumbs up. "That's the spirit!"

The first bite is literal heaven. Catra chews thoughtfully, leaning her head back against the seat. "Worth it, right?" Adora asks, watching her in amusement. Catra takes another bite and then nods, relaxing in her seat.

They eat in silence after that. Snow begins to collect on the window, and the noise of passersby laughing and chattering as they pass the car is strangely comforting. Catra's not too sure why they're eating here and not back at the apartment, but she's not really complaining. After staying cooped up inside all day, it feels good to finally get out, even if it's brief. She feels like something in Adora must have sensed that;almost as if she could empathize with her.

She turns to look at Adora now, who's staring through the window of the driver's seat. She's just taken a big bite, her cheeks sort of stuffed as she chews before a passing car lights up her face. Catra catches sight of her sharp jaw and the way her nose inclines in;her bright blue eyes that curiously scan the scenery. As if she can sense someone watching her, Adora then turns to face her, and lifts a questioning brow.

"What?" she asks, looking a little concerned.

Catra shakes her head and turns to look back at her burger, not quite sure why she was staring. "Nothing."

Adora ducks down to meet Catra's gaze once again, and this time, her voice is softer. "Are you sure?"

Something warm blossoms in Catra's chest, but she isn't sure what it is. What she does know is that she could get used to this feeling.

"Yeah," Catra says, honestly . "I'm sure."

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Halfway through midterms week, Catra comes home to a sight that's become somewhat familiar in the past few weeks: Glimmer and Bow cuddled up on the couch, while Adora lays sprawled across the floor.

They're watching something that they're all enticed by, if the way Glimmer obnoxiously makes a *shhh!* sound when Catra sets her bag down a little too loudly is anything to go by.

Catra figures out what it is the moment she sees a young Leonardo DiCaprio and Kate Winslet on screen, and can't help but be surprised. She didn't peg any of them ~~or~~ , maybe any of them except Bow ~~as~~ people who would be into tragic romance stories.

"Wow," Catra mutters, now feeling comfortable enough with them to make her way over to the middle of the living room where Adora is laying. "So all three of you are just hopeless romantics, huh?"

She doesn't get a response. Catra rolls her eyes when she realizes that the three of them really are just captivated by the movie, and decides that she may as well get comfortable as she sits down next to Adora, who eventually pushes herself up and matches Catra's position.

None of them say anything for a long time;not until the movie is coming to an end and Bow is sniffling behind them while Glimmer attempts to comfort her boyfriend. Catra leans back on her palms,

still thinking about how there was definitely enough room for both characters to get on top of that door when her thoughts are interrupted by Adora.

"I want something like that," she whispers, staring at the screen as the final scene happens.

"A tragic sacrificial love story that ultimately ends in you or your partner's death?" Catra questions. "I can't believe I'm saying this, but even *you* don't deserve that."

Adora snorts, and Catra smiles. She's never really had people laugh because of her, and the feeling is kind of nice. "Are you actually being nice to me?"

"Sorry," Catra mutters, "would you like me to insult what you're wearing instead?" she asks, referring to the fact that Adora is literally in a unicorn onesie.

Adora rolls her eyes, wearing an amused smile as she looks back up at the TV. "I meant~~I~~ want something like that, just, minus the death part." Then, out of Catra's peripheral vision, she sees Adora turn to watch her. "Something...something strong, and sure."

The feeling from before in Catra's chest grows, and her palms begin to sweat. She doesn't know what this all means, and it's kind of overwhelming.

(It's getting harder and harder to ignore.)

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Scorpia makes fun of her when Catra tells her over Christmas break. She's gone home with Scorpia to spend time with her moms ~~it'~~ s not like Catra really has anywhere else to go, being that Weaver is in prison and Lonnie isn't speaking to her ~~b~~ut she appreciates her mothers' welcome, and it's comforting and relaxing.

"It sounds like *someone* has a crush," is what Scorpia says after Catra describes the warm feeling she gets every time Adora is around, and how she's starting to not despise living there anymore; how she's actually kind of enjoying it.

And when Scorpia says that, Catra nearly splutters out the eggnog she had been previously drinking, because that's ~~t~~here' s no way that can be true. And besides, who the hell still calls it a crush? She's not some dumb school girl who gets flustered by pretty girls in skirts anymore.

"I'm sorry , I didn't know we were still in the eighth grade," Catra says, sarcastically, "what' s next, we braid each other's hair?" but Scorpia just laughs, and says, *it's true! You like her.*

Catra shakes her head in disapproval, because it's not true. She doesn't like Adora Grayskull.

(Catra doesn't bring it up for the rest of the break. Scorpia doesn't either.)

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JA~~N~~R Y.

Almost immediately upon getting back to their apartment after break ends, Catra begins to question herself.

The moment she steps inside and heads to their room, Adora, who seems to have gotten there recently too based off of the mess that is her clothes and suitcase, turns to look at her with a soft smile.

"Hey ," she greets, and she has her hair down for once and it's ~~it's~~ s beautiful. Adora is beautiful. Without another word, she steps closer to Catra, before slowly pulling her into a hug as if she's afraid she's going to run anyway. When Catra doesn't do anything to stop her, Adora hesitantly wraps her arms around Catra and softly squeezes, as if Catra is a small and fragile thing that could easily be broken. Catra wraps her own arms around Adora's waist, leaning her head against her shoulder. "I missed you."

Catra's not too sure how to reply to that, so she simply buries deeper into her and squeezes. Adora is warm and comforting and safe, and Catra is beginning to wonder if this is how home is supposed to feel.

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That night, they cook dinner together. They eat together, discuss how their breaks went (among other things), they do the dishes together, and it's…

It's really nice.

(Catra never would've imagined when she first moved in that she would eventually miss the rundown, little apartment in downtown Brooklyn, and that she would miss the person inside even more.)

They find themselves going to bed at the same time, too. It's not that late usually, Catra likes to go to bed later, but she's kind of tired from the events of the day.

Adora's already settled in bed as Catra finishes packing away the last of her suitcase when she whispers a quiet, "hey, Catra?"

Catra turns to look over her shoulder. Adora is lying on her back, staring up at the ceiling. "What's up?"

"Do you- do you ever get nightmares?" she hesitantly asks, eyes fluttering shut. Catra blinks, a little surprised, and opens her mouth to respond when Adora continues. "I'm sorry, that's a stupid question. Everyone does."

Folding the last of her clothes, Catra puts them into her drawer. She's not sure what possesses her to do so, but she tentatively makes her way to Adora's bed and sits down on the edge of it. Adora must either hear the squeak or feel the bed sink ever so slightly, because she opens her eyes and finds Catra's own eyes.

"Sometimes," she answers, staring down at Adora's hand and really wishing she could intertwine her own fingers with it. "Not often, though." Then, she thinks back to the beginning of last month; when she woke up to Adora randomly staring outside that window. "Is that -is that what that was? That one night?"

Adora must know what she's talking about, because she nods and swallows nervously. "Yeah. I just. sometimes they're really bad, and I can't go back to sleep afterwards, and it -it makes it worse when I'm sleeping alone? Which I know is stupid, because you're literally sleeping right over there, but-" she cuts herself off and squeezes her eyes shut, hands curling into the shape of a first. Catra takes the plunge and lays her hand over Adora's larger ones, gently uncurling them and then intertwining their fingers when Adora finally relaxes.

She doesn't know what to say. She never knows what to say, but what she doesn't know how to convey with words, she's learned to

convey with touch.

So Catra gets up and closes the door to their room, glad all of the other lights were already turned off. She turns off the lamplight sitting on the bedside table in the middle of both of their beds, and then slowly lowers herself onto Adora's bed.

There's literally only two blankets on her bed, and one of them is the sheet. She doesn't even sleep with an actual comforter, but as Catra gets settled, she understands why. "God, you're like a furnace."

Adora chuckles from somewhere near her left, and then moves a bit closer. She wraps an arm around Catra's shoulders in a loose embrace, and Catra curls into her.

There's a long moment of silence, aside from the sound of the fan and the cars outside their window. Sure that Adora's asleep, Catra's eyes flutter shut and her breathing begins to slow as she feels herself drifting off, only to hear a quiet, "thank you."

Catra blinks. She buries herself a bit deeper into Adora, feeling a bit like a koala clinging to a tree branch. "For what?"

"For being you," Adora answers, and her words are a bit slurred like she's on the edge of falling asleep.

Catra can't quite believe what she's hearing. Here Adora is, thanking her for being herself? As if she isn't some stuck-up asshole who ruins everything she touches?

"For being me?" Catra repeats, brows knit together in confusion. "What? That doesn't make any sense. I'm not even—I'm not a good person."

Adora squeezes her tighter. "You're a good person to me," she whispers. "You're good to Scorpia, and Perfuma. You're good to the people you care about." Catra's still shaking her head, but Adora

continues. "You got into bed with me just because sleeping next to someone is comforting for me."

(Catra doesn't know what to say. She never knows what to say.)

So instead, she takes a deep breath, and moves closer to Adora so that she can wrap an arm around her abdomen, squeezing tight. She lays her head down on her shoulder, and almost whines in relief when Adora pulls her impossibly tighter against herself and presses a kiss to her hair.

(Adora is warm and comforting and safe, and Catra knows now that she likes her.

She thinks she could love her.)

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Adora fits into her life like a puzzle piece she hadn't known she was missing.

They don't sleep together every night. Sometimes, Adora will go to bed early and Catra will go to bed late, and they'll sleep in their respective beds. Sometimes, Catra will go to bed at the same time as Adora and will hear a whispered *Catra?* and will just *know* as she crawls into Adora's bed. Sometimes, Catra will go to bed hours after Adora, and without a word, she'll get into Adora's bed without any prompting. Sometimes Adora won't be awake when Catra decides that she wants to sleep in Adora's bed, and sometimes she will, but she always wraps her arms around her and pulls her close every time Catra lays down next to her.

Catra and Glimmer reluctantly become acquaintances, and then friends, and then they're making fun of and pulling pranks on Bow and Adora and Adora is saying "I should've never introduced you two to each other," with a fond smile on her face. Catra starts inviting Scorpia over more often. At some point in the beginning of January, she's watching TV right after she gets back from class, and in a spur of the moment decision, picks up her phone and calls Lonnie.

(They talk for hours. It's emotional and cathartic, and when Adora opens the door to the apartment and finds Catra crying, she sets down her bags and settles on the couch next to her, and doesn't do more than reach for her hand and play with her fingers until Catra stops crying and leans on her shoulder.

When she finishes the phone call, she feels like a huge weight has finally been lifted from her shoulders.)

Their mornings start to smell like muttered conversations and warm coffee, which Adora makes sure to keep warm until Catra wakes. Catra, on most nights, makes them dinner, because although she's not the best, she's learning, and Adora can't really cook more than a microwavable meal without risk of burning the apartment down.

They do things together; just the two of them. They attend clubs and parties, but dance together as if they're the only ones. Adora takes Catra to an old, abandoned drive-in theatre her friend Sea Hawk discovered, and they spend the night cuddled up under a mound of blankets with s'mores, trying their best to stay warm in the frigid weather. They walk along the streets of New York, enjoying the light snow that falls and the cheerful strangers that walk by as they pass by buildings and stores with extremely expensive clothes being advertised in the windows. Adora makes jokes about how overpriced it all is, and Catra laughs along with her. It occurs to her that, at a time, she used to be able to afford everything in that shop.

It doesn't hurt; not like she thought it would.

She feels *free.*

Sometimes, they don’t go out at all. Sometimes they’ll just stay in, a beer in both their hands as they recall stories like *so this one time…* They’ll watch movies late at night, and Catra will make fun of Adora for hiding behind her and screaming at every single jump scare whenever they watch a horror movie. Catra will get up with Adora every time she can’t sleep, not even Catra’s presence being enough to calm her, and they’ll talk about everything and anything as they eat cereal at four in the morning until Adora feels ready to go back to sleep. It doesn’t matter to Catra that she knows she’ll be exhausted come morning, because Adora is worth it.

She’s always been worth it.

There’s one night that Catra finds herself up late at their tiny kitchen table due to last minute studying, but also because she wants to take advantage of the empty apartment since Adora is out pre-training for soccer season. She doesn’t even realize she must have accidentally fallen asleep until sometime later when she wakes up to strong and sure arms wrapped around her, carrying her toward their room.

“Adora?” she sleepily whispers. Adora smells like fresh soap and safety, and Catra finds herself unconsciously curling into her.

“Shh,” Adora hushes just after setting Catra down on the bed; Catra can’t tell who’s it is. “Go back to sleep.” She runs a gentle, soothing hand through her hair before beginning to pull away, and Catra, in her sleep-delirious state, whines in protest before reaching for Adora’s hand.

“Adora,” she repeats, voice slurred. “Stay .”

“I have to turn of f all the lights and get ready for bed,” Adora reminds her, but she doesn’t pull away any further; in fact, her grip on Catra’ s hand tightens. Catra feels herself beginning to slip away, so she doesn’t say anything else.

Just before sleep overcomes her , she feels the bed sink beside her, followed by the feeling of arms wrapping around her and pulling into

a comfortable embrace.

(When they wake up the next morning to find her papers still scattered over the table and the kitchen light still on, Catra smiles to herself before pulling Adora into a hug. When Adora hugs her back but confusingly asks her what it's for, Catra simply repeats *for being you* into her shoulder.)

On Adora's twenty-second birthday, for the first time in possibly *ever,* Catra willingly wakes herself up in the early, *early* hours of the morning before she knows Adora will wake up. She spends about half an hour trying her best to follow a recipe for cake she found online, and surprisingly enough, it goes well. She's about to check if it's cool enough to put icing on when she feels hands on her waist and nearly jumps in surprise.

"Adora," she whines while Adora spends a good few seconds laughing, "you aren't supposed to be awake. I was going to surprise you."

Adora hums, tucking her face into Catra's shoulder. "You got up at five a.m. to make a cake for me? Wow, you must *really* like me."

Catra rolls her eyes. "This is not because I like you," she mutters, but only leans further back into the comforting weight behind her.

Adora squeezes Catra's waist before she let's go of her. They spend the rest of the morning icing the cake together, and then Catra tells Adora to sit down at the table so she can put candles into it and sing happy birthday. It's nearly six in the morning by the time they start eating in a comfortable silence.

Catra is actually eating a cake ~~-so~~mething she was really never allowed to eat before ~~-a~~t six in the morning in a lower middle-class apartment in downtown Brooklyn, occasionally sneaking glances at her roommate, who's smiling to herself as she licks icing off of her spoon.

She doesn’t know what she’s doing, but it feels a lot like falling in love.

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FEBRUARY.

It’s about a week before Valentine’s Day when things starts to change.

Every time Catra talks to Scorpia —whether it’s on the phone or in person —the conversation always starts with something similar to “so, are you and Adora together yet?”

Today, the only difference is that Perfuma has decided to join them. Now, they’re at the coffee shop down the street that Adora took her to a few weeks ago, and they’re both staring at her.

“I’m literally begging you,” Catra says, seconds away from chucking her iced tea into Scorpia’s face and sprinting out the door, “to ask something else, because *nothing* has changed.”

Perfuma takes a sip of her coffee, and Scorpia’s eyes widen. “But I thought you liked”—

“I do like her!” Catra interrupts, surprising both Perfuma and Scorpia. With a sigh, Catra rubs her eyes. “I’m sorry. I just—I—*do* like her.” She thinks she might love her, but she’s not going to admit that to them. “But I don’t know if she likes me back, and I can’t just *tell* her without knowing, because what if she doesn’t like me like that and then she makes me move out or something?”

Scorpia's eyes are still wide as she stares at her, and Perfuma's watching her with a look of disbelief.

"You're scared she doesn't like you back?" she asks, brows nearly lifted to her hairline. Catra straightens up a bit. It's not that she doesn't like hearing Scorpia's advice, but Perfuma is actually friends with Adora, and has been for a few years. She'll have a different perspective on this. "Catra, she talks about you *all* of the time."

"Yeah, but"—

"No buts," Perfuma interrupts, soft but firm, "seriously. I've never seen her this happy. If you were to ask me, I would say she definitely reciprocates your feelings."

She says it so simply, sitting back in her chair and taking another sip of her coffee as if she hasn't just knocked Catra's entire world off its axis. This whole *I might be in love with my roommate and I don't know what to do about it* thing—she's spent all this time questioning her own feelings and wondering what to do about it that she hadn't ever really considered it possibly being mutual.

Perfuma's words linger in the back of her mind for the rest of the day, and she tries not to read into it too much every time she looks over at Adora and finds that she's already looking at her with a soft smile on her face.

A few days before Valentine's Day, Catra's going to their room to grab a jacket because she's going out with Double Trouble and a couple of their friends to a party, and passes the bathroom, where Adora is fixing her hair.

"Oh," Catra says, coming to a halt outside of the doorway. She had invited Adora to come along like they always did when the other was invited to a party, but she had politely declined. "Did you change your mind?" Adora shakes her head, so Catra adds, "have any plans?"

"Yeah," Adora nods. "I'm going on a date."

Now *that* makes Catra do a double take. *“What?”*

Adora sighs, almost as if she doesn’t even *want* to go. “One of Bow’ s friends set me up on a blind date in celebration of Valentine’s Day, so I..I figured I’d give it a shot, I guess.”

Catra stares at her for a few moments. Adora still isn’t looking at her, but eventually, she sort of shuffles her feet and then meets her eyes.

“Oh,” is all Catra says. There’ s a moment of awkward silence, and then Catra nods, trying to ignore the crushing feeling sprouting somewhere in her chest. “Okay . Have fun,” she tells her in the most monotonous voice she can muster.

(She grabs her jacket, and she leaves.)

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Catra doesn’t *really* mean to avoid their apartment for nearly two days, but that’s exactly what she does. She hadn’t wanted to go back after the party, considering she was so drunk she could barely walk, and by the time she was sober again, every time she thought about going back she kind of wanted to cry.

When she comes back, it’s the day before Valentine’s. She arrives in the afternoon after class, mostly because she knows Adora is still stuck in her medical terminology lecture and that she won’t be at home, but what she doesn’t expect is to find Adora standing in the kitchen, a half eaten cup of ramen in her hands. She’s staring at

Catra like a deer caught in the headlights, and Catra imagines she doesn't look much different.

There's a moment of silence, before Catra nervously swallows and closes the door. Adora sets down her cup of noodles, and sighs.

"Where have you been?" she asks, and it doesn't even sound accusatory, just sad. She looks up to meet Catra's eyes, and they're full of concern. "I was so worried. I mean—we *live* together and you went to a party, and you didn't come back afterward and you didn't answer your calls, and I had to find out through *Scorpia* that you were alright almost twenty four hours later"—

"Adora," Catra cuts her off, taking a deep breath. She knows she's crying because her eyes are blurry, but thankfully, the tears haven't fallen yet. "Please, just—just stop, because I *can't."*

Adora's mouth immediately shuts, and Catra nearly debates leaving again, but ultimately decides that would probably end up making everything worse. After a moment of silence, Catra heavily swallows, and then retreats to their shared room.

Using Scorpia's sweater to wipe her eyes, Catra slings her backpack onto the foot of her bed and curls up underneath the covers. Doing her best not to think about any of it, she goes to sleep.

It's a little while later when there's a soft knock on the door. Catra groggily opens her eyes and groans;it must be late into the evening if the sunset lighting up their room is anything to go by.

There's another knock, a little bit louder this time, and Catra sighs and sits up. She rubs her eyes, and then mumbles a half-hearted "come in."

Adora slowly opens the door, and then tentatively peeks in. When she sees Catra sitting up and already facing the door, she opens it all the way. Neither one of them says anything for a while, until eventually, Adora nervously speaks as she bounces on the balls of her feet. "Are you...are you mad at me?"

Catra sighs, because to be honest, she's not quite sure. Why would she be mad at Adora? None of this is her fault; not really, but she needs *someone* to be mad at, and it's Adora's fault for making her fall in love with her.

"No," is what she mutters despite this. Adora stares at her like she doesn't believe her, and Catra frowns, fiddling nervously with the sleeves of her sweater. There's another long moment of silence, and then Catra swings her legs over the side of the bed and stands up. She steps past Adora and toward the living room, not sure if she wants to leave again or sulk while taking a long shower.

Adora doesn't give her the chance to decide. "Yes, you are," she says, turning around to follow Catra into the kitchen. "You're mad at me."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Wow, you want a medal for that realization, genius?" she asks, opening their near empty fridge. With a ping of guilt, she remembers they were supposed to go grocery shopping yesterday; Adora must have decided to wait for her to go.

"Why?" Adora asks, and when Catra turns around, Adora's fists are clenched and she's staring at Catra like she's a puzzle that needs to be solved. "What did I do?"

Catra's silent. How is she supposed to tell Adora that she didn't do anything *wrong,* not really, except unknowingly break Catra's heart? "Nothing," she eventually mutters, despite knowing that won't cut it. "Just—just drop it, Adora."

"No," Adora snaps and Catra widens her eyes. "I'm not just—you can't just be mad at me and not tell me why. That's not fair. I want to

fix this—I want to fix whatever I did, and I want you to stop being so weird and distant."Catra clenches her jaw and shakes her head, turning to stare at something else. Eventually, though, Adora seems to piece it together herself. "You started acting like this after I told you I was going on that date,"she says, almost to herself. Then, she takes a step closer, despite the fact that they're still on opposite ends of the kitchen and their tiny table is separating them. "Is this about that?Are you mad I went on a date?"

Again, Catra doesn't reply. Adora's eyes seem to soften, and she sighs. "Catra, if you wanted me to go with you to the party instead, you could've just told me. The date wasn't—she wasn't even that great, anyway."

"It's not about that,"Catra snaps, glaring at Adora will all of the intensity that she can muster. "It's the fact that you wanted to go on a date. You're *looking* for people to date, and—and"—

"What is your problem, Catra?"Adora interrupts, and she's raising her voice now. "Why are you acting like this?Why is me going on a date such a *problem* for you?"—

"Because I think I'm in love with you!"Catra interrupts, shouting now. "Because—because you're *you,* and I'm in love with you, and it *hurts so much* to know that you want to date other people, and"—

There's hands cupping her face. Adora's hands are cupping her face, and she pulls Catra into her and kisses her, slow and languid and full of so much passion like they aren't standing in the middle of a small, rundown apartment with cockroaches scuttling underneath the floorboards and paint crumbling off the walls.

It feels like home.

"The only reason I went on that date was to get over you,"Adora tells her, pulling back to rest their foreheads together. Catra doesn't even realize she's crying until she feels Adora softly wipe her cheeks with her thumbs, before pressing her lips where her thumbs were.

"You—to get over me?"Catra asks in disbelief, unconsciously bringing her hands up to tangle in the back of Adora's hair. "Does—does that mean?"—

"I love you too,"Adora answers, voice so soft it's barely above a whisper. "God, Catra, you don't understand how happy I am. I thought you didn't feel the same way."

Catra lets out a noise that's a cross between a sob and laughter. "Trust me, Adora, I understand,"she tells her, and without thinking, she pulls their lips back together.

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JULY.

Catra's twenty-two when they move into a new place;a nice, bigger apartment on the Upper West Side of New York. They both have good jobs now, Catra getting ready to split her time between that, Adora, and grad school.

She doesn't think she's ever been this happy.

It's the midst of summer now, and they've called most of their friends to help them move their things into the U-Haul and into the new apartment despite the fact that really, they don't have much.

"Hey,"Adora greets, approaching her from the hallway as Catra finds herself staring at the now empty apartment from the doorway. She was supposed to leave the keys, lock the door, and meet them downstairs, but she couldn't quite bring herself to leave.

Adora's hair is falling from her ponytail, and she's sweaty and a bit out of breath from the sweltering heat and the multiple trips up and down the stairs, but she wraps an arm around Catra's shoulders and presses a kiss to her temple. "You okay?" Catra nods, leaning into her girlfriend, so Adora rubs up and down her arm and says, "you sure?"

Catra sighs. "I'm just—I'm just thinking about how weird it is that all of this happened. I mean, I moved in here absolutely *dreading* it. I had just gone from being apart of a millionaire family to having like twelve dollars in my bank account." Adora chuckles and presses another kiss to her forehead at her girlfriend's exaggeration. "—and this place just taught me so much, you know? I'm really going to miss it."

Adora listens attentively. When Catra finishes, Adora grabs her hands and pulls her further into the apartment.

"Can I be honest?" she asks, turning to face Catra and grabbing her other hand so that both of their hands are intertwined with each other's, swinging them side to side. Catra tells her *of course,* so Adora continues. "I'm not gonna miss this place."

That catches Catra a bit off guard. "Seriously?"

Adora nods, and she's staring at Catra like she's the reason the stars illuminate the sky at night and sunflowers bloom in grasslands. Then, she glances around and wrinkles her nose, and Catra doesn't consider herself to be dramatic, but it is quite literally the cutest thing she's ever seen. "Yeah. You were right about one thing when you got here, and that's that this place *sucks.* Like, come on, the walls are so thin you can hear everything our neighbors do, it smells like smoke more often than not, and the water pressure *is* kind of shitty."

Catra follows Adora's lead and glances around one more time; there's cracked paint on the walls and random dark spots in the carpets. "I know that," she says, softly, "but it's still home."

Adora's arms come to wrap around her waist, and she smiles sweetly, face a few inches away from Catra's. "*You're* my home, Catra," she mumbles right up against her lips, causing Catra's chest to clench due to what's probably the most love she's ever felt for anything.

"Cheesy," Catra complains, but she wraps her arms around Adora's neck and kisses her despite it.

(Catra's twenty-two when she realizes that home was never a place. Home is where her heart is, and her heart belongs to a warm and comforting and safe blonde with a stupid hair poof and a beautiful smile.)

*

End Notes

thanks for reading!comments/feedback and kudos as always are my serotonin and are very appreciated!

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